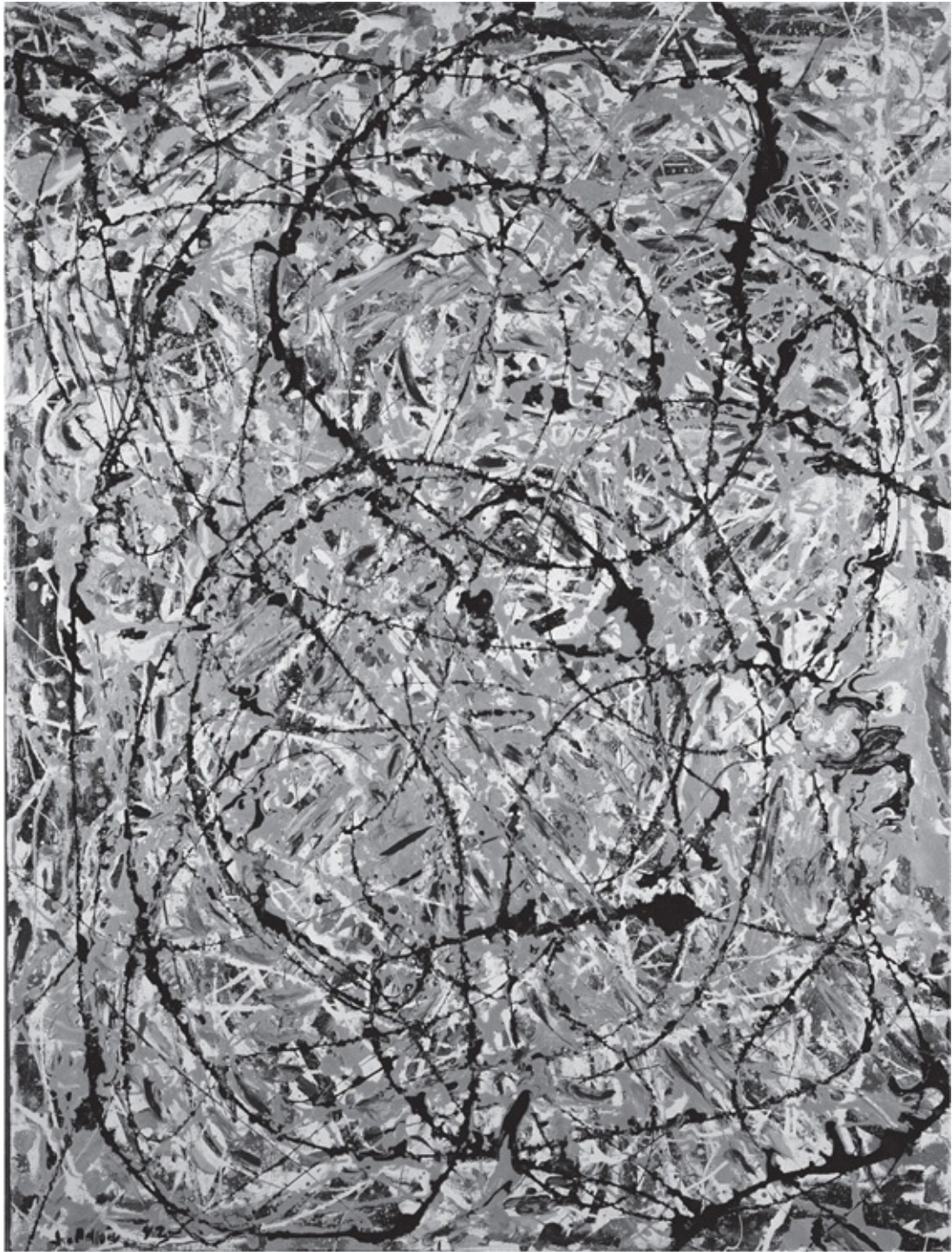


Abstract Expressionism

As Europe struggled to recover in the aftermath of the Second World War, America moved into a position of political, economic and cultural power. The Abstract Expressionists were a small group of loosely associated artists who had worked in diverse styles before the war, but by the 1940s began working in radical new directions, reflecting the mood of the moment. As the first US art movement to have an international impact, they ultimately led to New York supplanting Paris as the centre of the art world. Lacking a precise definition, Abstract Expressionism was inspired by various ideas, particularly Surrealism, many of whose followers had fled to America during the war. Most Abstract Expressionists built on the ideas of automatism, producing paintings generated by their innermost feelings, using spontaneous gestures and uninhibited action. This became known as Action Painting, or Gestural Abstraction. The artists dripped, poured and threw paint over their canvases as they expressed their inner emotions. Those involved included Jackson Pollock (1912–56), Willem de Kooning (1904–97), Arshile Gorky (1904–48) and Franz Kline (1910–62).



Pollock, *Watery Paths*, 1947